
UNODC
STUDY GUIDE

Agenda Item: Combating Criminal Networks Operating on Dark Web

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. **Letter from Head of Academy**
2. **Letter from the USG of UNODC**
3. **Introduction to the Committee**
   - 3.1. What is UNODC?
   - 3.2. History of UNODC?
4. **Introduction to the Agenda Item**
   - 4.1. What is the Dark Web?
     - 4.1.1. The Differences Between Dark Web and Deep Web
     - 4.1.2. Dark Web Access Technologies
     - 4.1.3. The Working Mechanisms of Dark Web
   - 4.2. Criminal Networks Operating On Dark Web
     - 4.2.1. Illegal Drug Trafficking
     - 4.2.2. Illegal Arms Trafficking
     - 4.2.3. Cyber Crimes
     - 4.2.4. Child Abuse
     - 4.2.5. Laundering Black Money
     - 4.2.6. Criminal Support Services
     - 4.2.7. Human Trafficking
     - 4.2.8. Terrorism
5. **Key Words and Their Definitions**
6. **Background of the Issue**
7. **Previous and Ongoing Efforts**
   - 7.1. Biggest Hits and International Operations
     - 7.1.1. Operation Alice (March 2026)
     - 7.1.2. Operation Cronos (February 2024)
     - 7.1.3. Operation First Light (2024)
     - 7.1.4. Operation Archetype (June 2025)
   - 7.2. Education Programs and Development Movements
     - 7.2.1. Jamaica Education Programs (March 2025)
     - 7.2.2. Qatar Education Program (August 2026)
     - 7.2.3. UNODC's Global Cyber Attacks Education Program
     - 7.2.4. Ukraine Project of UNODC
8. **UNODC's Approach to Combating Dark Web Criminal Networks**
   - 8.1. Education Expertise and Capacity Development
   - 8.2. International Operation Coordination
   - 8.3. Public-Private Sector Collaboration
   - 8.4. Research and Threat Analysis
   - 8.5. Awareness and Prevention Campaigns
   - 8.6. Legal and Regulatory Framework Development
9. **Resolution Should Address**
10. **Bibliography**

1. Letter From Head of Academy

Dear Delegates,
First of all, I would like to say that I am honored to welcome you all to DALMUN'26. As the Head of Academy, my team and I look forward to hearing about the bright ideas and creative solutions that you will bring to this conference, and especially to this committee. As delegates of the UNODC committee, each and every one of you has the responsibility to address global challenges, exchange ideas, and work towards creating effective and sustainable solutions. You have the opportunity to step into the shoes of the leaders who make important decisions around the world. Throughout this committee, you will be expected to approach complex issues from different perspectives while working towards solutions.

With the rapid development of technology and the increasing interconnectedness of societies, criminal networks have found new ways to operate beyond traditional borders. The dark web has created additional challenges for law enforcement and international cooperation, allowing criminal activities to take place while making the identification of those involved more difficult. Combating these networks requires not only effective national measures, but also strong international cooperation, information sharing, and coordination between relevant institutions.

I encourage each of you to research your country's position thoroughly, understand the existing international frameworks concerning cybercrime and transnational organized crime, and consider both the opportunities and challenges presented by different approaches. As you develop your solutions, remember the importance of balancing security and law enforcement with privacy, human rights, national sovereignty, and the responsible use of technology.
Most importantly, remember that Model United Nations is not simply about defending a position; it is about diplomacy, cooperation, and finding common ground.
On behalf of the academy, I wish you all an engaging, productive, and memorable committee. I look forward to witnessing the diplomacy, creativity, and leadership you bring to the floor.

Best regards,

Dila Asya TOPÇU
Head of Academy

E-Mail: topcudilaasya@gmail.com

2.Letter from Under Secretary General of UNODC

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) Committee. My name is Mete, and I am a high school student serving as the Under-Secretary-General of this committee. I am very proud to welcome you to this conference.

In this committee, our main topic is one of the biggest security challenges of the 21st century: combating criminal networks operating on the dark web. As delegates, you will discuss serious problems such as illegal drug and arms trade, cybercrimes and ransomware, money laundering with cryptocurrencies, and the protection of children from online abuse. We will also talk about how countries can work together, use digital evidence, and balance cybersecurity with human rights.

I encourage all of you to join the debates actively, respect different opinions, and work together. Good debates are built on teamwork, diplomacy, and mutual respect. If this is your first MUN conference, do not worry; our chairboard will do our best to help you feel comfortable and make your experience great.

I wish you good luck with your preparations, and I look forward to meeting you all. If you have any questions, please feel free to contact me.

Best regards,

Mete GÜZEL
Co-Under Secretary General of UNODC

E-Mail: meteguzell2011@icloud.com

3.Introduction to the Committee

3.1. What is UNODC?

The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) has identified criminal networks operating on the dark web as 21. It considers it one of the most complex and rapidly transforming security threats of the century and places the fight against these networks at the center of its corporate strategy. The dark web hosts a wide range of illegal activities such as drug trafficking, arms trafficking, human trafficking, cyber attacks, identity theft, dissemination of child abuse materials, terrorism financing and money laundering using technologies that provide anonymity (such as Tor, I2P, Freenet) and cryptocurrency systems. The transnational nature of these criminal networks necessitates an innovative, coordinated and internationally integrated approach to combat beyond traditional law enforcement methods. In this context, UNODC is carrying out a comprehensive work programme aimed at strengthening the capacity of member states to detect, investigate, prosecute and prevent crimes caused by the dark web; it is also leading the development of international legal frameworks and cooperation mechanisms in this area. The three key pillars of UNODC's work program to combat criminal networks on the dark web are as follows:

Research and analytical studies: conducting academic and operational research that examines in depth the dynamics of the functioning of the dark web ecosystem, the forms of organization of criminal networks, how anonymization technologies are abused and how cryptocurrency flows can be tracked; collecting intelligence on criminal activities on illegal marketplaces, forums and communication channels, and analyzing this data to provide evidence-based information to the policy-making and operational decision-making processes of member states; Additionally, to contribute to the development of proactive strategies by early detection of new threat trends and modus operandi on the dark web.

Normative activities: To provide legal advice and technical support for member states to harmonize their national criminal codes, cybercrime legislation and digital evidence collection procedures with international standards and conventions (such as the Budapest Convention, the Palermo Convention, the Convention Against Corruption) in order to effectively combat crimes caused by the dark web; to encourage the strengthening of legal frameworks on legal assistance, extradition and evidence sharing between countries in order to prevent criminal networks operating on the dark web from taking advantage of jurisdictional gaps; and to carry out studies for the regulation of crypto assets, the supervision of decryption tools and the implementation of new normative regulations on the responsibilities of online platforms.

Field-based technical cooperation projects: Organizing intensive training programs and field applications on dark network investigations, cryptocurrency monitoring and analysis techniques (blockchain analysis, decoding mixers, cooperation with secret services), obtaining and protecting

digital evidence for use in court, dark web market infiltration operations and deciphering online identity concealment methods for law enforcement agencies, prosecutors, judges and financial intelligence units; in this context, developing and implementing specific response plans for each country's own dark web threat profile by cooperating directly with local institutions through UNODC's 21 field offices around the world; as well as limiting the transnational mobility of criminal networks on the dark web by supporting intelligence sharing between countries, joint operation centers and the establishment of rapid response teams.

UNODC adopts a holistic approach including preventive measures, public-private sector collaborations and civil society participation, aware that only technological and operational solutions are not enough to combat criminal networks on the dark web. The office leads the development of balanced policies on the supervision and regulation of these technologies, taking into account the fine line between the legitimate uses of cryptocurrencies and Decryption tools used on the dark web and their criminal use. In addition, it also conducts extensive studies to protect the victims of dark web crimes, quickly detect and remove child abuse materials, and identify and confiscate the proceeds from these crimes. Through its field offices and cooperation networks in 21 locations around the world, UNODC continues its work with determination to increase the resilience of member states to threats caused by the dark web and to narrow the scope of activity of these criminal networks.

3.2. History of UNODC

The roots of the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) can be traced back to the Shanghai Opium Commission of 1909 and the first international opium convention of 1912, which were the first concrete steps in international drug control. These efforts continued during the League of Nations period and were transferred to the newly established United Nations body after the Second World War and gained an institutional identity with the establishment of the Commission on Narcotic Substances (CND) in 1946.

While the three main international conventions signed in 1961, 1971 and 1988 constitute the legal framework of today's global drug control system, studies in the field of crime prevention have also been shaped by the UN Crime Congresses organized since the 1950s.

The emergence of UNODC in its modern form occurred in 1997 through the reform initiatives of then-UN Secretary-General Kofi Annan. Within the scope of this reform, the United Nations Drug Control Programme (UNDCP), which was established in 1991, and the Crime Prevention and The Criminal Justice Department was merged to create the "Drug Control and Crime Prevention Office". This merger, recognizing the strong link between drug trafficking and organized crime, has carried the goal of managing both areas more effectively under a single corporate roof. Dec. On October 1, 2002, with the official integration of all UNDCP resources and personnel into this structure, the name of the office was changed to UNODC, which is its current short form.

After its establishment, UNODC's jurisdiction has gradually expanded; with the opening of the United Nations Convention Against Corruption (UNCAC) for signature in 2003, and with the establishment of the Anti-Terrorism Branch in 2004, Deconflicting terrorism has also been included among the official responsibilities of the office. Together with the strategic frameworks adopted in the 2010s, UNODC will continue its operational and normative work in the 16th Century, aiming at the Sustainable Development Goals, especially peace, justice and strong institutions. It has adopted an approach that directly relates to the substance. Today, UNODC continues its activities through three main pillars: field technical cooperation, global research and analysis studies, and normative activities for the implementation of international conventions.

4.Introduction to the Agenda Item

4.1. What Is The Dark Web?

The dark web is the World Wide Web content that exists on darknets (overlay networks) that use the internet, but require specific software, configurations, or authorization to access.Through the dark web, private computer networks can communicate and conduct business anonymously without divulging identifying information, such as a user's location. The dark web forms a small part of the deep web, the part of the web not indexed by web search engines, although sometimes the term deep web is mistakenly used to refer specifically to the dark web.The darknets which constitute the dark web include small, friend-to-friend networks, as well as large, popular networks such as Tor, Hyphanet,
12P, and Riffle operated by public organizations and individuals.Users of the dark web refer to the regular web as clearnet due to its unencrypted nature.The
Tor dark web or onionland uses the traffic anonymization technique of onion routing under the network's top-level domain suffix onion.

4.1.1. Differences Between Dark Web and Deep Web

Access to the Deep Web begins with a layered login system that operates in a client-server architecture and authenticates user credentials using protocols such as LDAP or OAuth. For each approved request, the server creates a unique session token, which allows the user to access certain records in the database only according to the authorization level. Database queries (SQL or NoSQL) are executed dynamically, and the results are returned after undergoing user-specific filtering operations. This dynamic structure makes it impossible for search engine bots to cache the content, and each query generates a unique response.

While all data is encrypted with TLS 1.3 during transmission, sensitive content is protected with AES-256 symmetric encryption during storage, and these passwords can only be decrypted with the logged-in user's private key. On the server side, every operation is recorded by real-time monitoring systems (SIEM), and abnormal access attempts are detected instantly and the session is terminated. Database management systems use B-tree or hash indexes for query optimization, allowing the desired data to be found among millions of records within milliseconds. The majority of Deep Web

servers work with load balancing algorithms and provide uninterrupted service by distributing incoming requests to multiple physical servers. All these mechanisms make it possible for the Deep Web to offer dynamic content created instantly for each user, instead of static HTML pages, unlike the surface network. This infrastructure forms the foundation for the secure and functional operation of the Deep Web.

The data flow on the Deep Web is based on parameterized queries sent via the POST and PUT methods, unlike standard GET requests made over HTTP. During the session period, the user's movements are recorded in the server-side transaction logs (transaction log) and these logs are stored for forensic analysis in case of a possible security breach. On the database layer, row-level security is applied, allowing different users to access different data even within the same table. All these mechanisms demonstrate that the Deep Web is a robust infrastructure designed for corporate, academic, and commercial use. The Dark Web, on the other hand, remains an anonymized and much smaller exception to this system.

4.1.2. Dark Web Access Technologies

The main technology used to access the Dark Web is the Tor (The Onion Router) network, which encrypts traffic in multiple layers and routes it through volunteer servers scattered around the world in order to hide the identities and locations of users. In this network, data typically passes through three different transmitters (input, middle, and output nodes), and each transmitter does not see any information other than the one before and the one after it, so no single point can know both the identity of the user and the site he visited. Creating different circuits for each connection and discarding encryption keys when the circuit Octobers provides an additional layer of protection against traffic analysis attacks.

Offering a different approach from Tor, I2P (Invisible Internet Project) works with a completely distributed and packet-switched architecture; in contrast to Tor's centralized directory serverdependent structure, I2P eliminates centralized checkpoints using a self-organized Tier of DHT (Distributed Hash Table). I2P, separates the incoming and outgoing traffic in one-way tunnels (tunnels are unidirectional) communicates with the encrypted message and more than one in a single package, which combines the "garlic routing" (garlic routing) technique by using the timing correlation attacks more difficult. These differences make I2P more suitable especially for Decrypted services and peer-to-peer applications within the network, while Tor is optimized for anonymous access to ordinary Internet sites (clearnet).

In order to provide secure access, researchers and users implement a multi-Octane security strategy (defense in depth) with Tor, using additional layers such as VPN (Virtual Private Network), SOCKS5 proxy or privacy-oriented operating systems such as Whonix. This approach makes it difficult for local observers, such as an Internet Service Provider (ISP), to detect Tor usage and provides additional protection against possible security risks of the exit node. Oct. In addition, the bridge transporters used by Tor to circumvent censorship and plug-in plug-ins that hide traffic

reveal the dynamic nature of access technology, which is constantly evolving and resistant to censorship mechanisms.

4.1.3. The Mechanism of Dark Web

The mechanism of operation of the Dark Web is based on the principle of Decrypted tunnels, which are created mutually between the client and the secret service, and the interconnection of these tunnels. A user connects to a . via the Tor network.when the client wants to access the onion address, the client first learns the promotion points of that secret service from the directory servers and then creates its own meeting point. The covert service, on the other hand, establishes a circuit on its side, activates the access points, and connects to the client's meeting point via these points; Thus, a fully encrypted circuit consisting of 6 relays is completed between the client and the service. During this process, the IP address of the secret service is never disclosed, because all communication takes place only through anonymous circuits created within the Tor network. In addition, each secret service periodically changes its own promotion points, and these points can only be verified by the signature published by the service, thus preventing attacks on fake promotion points.

The meeting point is the first point of contact where the connection between the client and the secret service is established, and both parties connect to this point separately via encrypted tunnels; the meeting point is responsible for transmitting only Decrypted data packets without knowing the identities of the parties. Thanks to this mechanism, neither the location of the server hosting the hidden service nor the client's real IP address is leaked to the other party or third parties. The communication between the client and the service is protected by Decryption keys created separately at both ends, and these keys are completely destroyed when the circuit is terminated. Each transmitter on the network decodes only its own encryption layer and learns the address of the next transmitter, so no single node can view the entire communication. The Tor network October also use additional protocols, such as silent key exchange, to increase the privacy of the service, which allows only clients with a pre-shared key to access the service. Although this complex circuit structure slows down the speed of the Tor network, the level of anonymity it provides offers effective resistance to even the most powerful surveillance mechanisms today.

In the I2P network, the functioning mechanism, unlike Tor, relies on each application creating a tunnel within itself; each tunnel is used only for a specific service or application, and all traffic is routed through these tunnels. Tunnels in I2P are divided into two categories: outgoing and incoming: outgoing tunnels carry data from the client to the destination; incoming tunnels carry data from the destination to the client, and these two tunnels are completely independent of each other.

Each tunnel consists of 3 to 7 transmitters randomly selected, and these transmitters are nodes voluntarily operated by other participants in the network. During the tunnel creation process, a separate encryption key is sent to each relay, and data is encrypted layer by layer with these keys and transmitted between the relays. I2P's garlic routing technique sends multiple messages by

combining them into a single packet, which makes traffic analysis attacks largely ineffective due to the inability to understand which message the packets belong to. All these processes automatically process in the background for the user and maintain anonymity by constantly creating new tunnels without the user having to make any additional planting configurations.

4.2. Criminal Networks Operating on Dark Web

Crimes on the Dark Web cover a wide range of illegal activities such as drug and arms trafficking, as well as the sale of stolen data, identity theft, ransomware services and the production of fake documents. Sensitive data such as personal information, bank account login information and internal company documents regularly find buyers on these platforms, and this data is usually obtained from major data breaches. In addition, professional criminal services such as cyberattack services for hire, production of fake passports and driver's licenses, money laundering consulting are also widely offered in these marketplaces.

4.2.1. Drug Trafficking

The drug trade on the Dark Web is emerging as a black economy that has reached a volume of billions of dollars globally and is becoming increasingly professionalized. approximately $ 2.6 billion of cryptocurrency flows took place in these markets in 2025, which shows how resilient the markets are despite the interventions of law enforcement agencies. These markets, which have ceased to be isolated platforms from each other, have transformed into a global supply network by establishing wholesale supply relationships among themselves. For example, after the closure of Abacus Market, which was an important Sunday for Western users, TorZon quickly filled the gap in the ecosystem by taking over this central role. This connected structure shows that the closure of a single Sunday, instead of solving the problem, causes sellers and buyers to migrate to other platforms and redirect capital within the network. The fact that about 70% of sellers continued to operate with the same username on new platforms during this migration wave reveals that their identities are traceable despite the anonymity tools, which offers an opportunity for law enforcement agencies.

Trust and reputation mechanisms play a vital role in the functioning of markets, and this is reflected in the way sellers present their products. On some platforms, sellers provide only minimal information such as product name and contact information, while in more professional Sundays information such as the percentage of purity of products, independent laboratory test results and detailed impact statements are often shared. Such applications help buyers manage their risk perception while also serving as a reliability indicator for sellers. Moreover, these Sundays are not only retail outlets, but also exhibit vertical integration models in direct connection with large-scale drug production laboratories. This complex structure poses significant challenges for law enforcement, and large scale operations (for example, in Europe Fabryka Operation) requires editing. Sunday Sunday The fact that the quantities of drugs seized in these operations are equivalent to only 1-2% of the annual global market volume shows the limited impact of law enforcement interventions and how large the markets are. Markets Decider mechanisms

(arbitration) have also become an indispensable part of the markets besides reputation scoring and these systems appoint third party arbitrators who intervene within 48 hours to resolve disputes between the parties.

Research shows that going beyond the law enforcement strategy of closing down entire Sundays, focusing on critical nodal points of the network can be more effective. For example, the arrest of a major seller in Silk Road 2.0 led to a 39% decrease in transaction volume and a 56% decrease in the number of sellers in the following period. It has been observed that this deterrent effect also has a positive bounce effect on sellers outside the jurisdiction of the country where the arrest was made. On the other hand, the presence of the drug trade in these anonymous networks is not limited only to the criminal economy, but also has direct effects on public health. Analyses conducted on cryptocurrency flows reveal that constrictions in the supply chain of deadly substances such as fentanyl can predict decreases in overdose deaths months in advance. This situation demonstrates that blockchain data can be used as an early warning system long before traditional health statistics. Also, in 2024, the usage rate of hard-to-track cryptocurrencies such as Monero in these Sundays has reached 65%, which marks the beginning of a new era in which traditional Bitcoin analyses are insufficient. Markets Jul, it is known that about 40% of the drugs sold in these markets are produced in synthetic laboratories in Europe and these laboratories are fed with precursor chemicals supplied from China.

4.2.2. Arms Trafficking

Arms trafficking on the Dark Web is a smaller but extremely dangerous and rapidly growing black market segment compared to the drug trade. On Sundays Dec. 2024, the annual transaction volume in these markets is estimated to be between 350-500 million dollars, and it is observed that this figure has increased by 25% compared to previous years. Unlike other illegal marketplaces, the arms trade is carried out by a smaller number of sellers, and these sellers are usually limited to only a few dozen active traders. Pistols, shotguns, semi-automatic rifles and grenades are among the most sold products, while more recently, rocket launchers, mines and even small-caliber mortars are also listed. The prices of these products fluctuate greatly according to the intensity of global conflict and disruptions in the supply chain; for example, with the outbreak of a large-scale war, it has been observed that market prices increase by an average of 40%. In addition, about 60% of sellers prefer to sell their products wholesale rather than retail, indicating that the majority of the global arms flow takes place from a small number of hands.

The functioning of the arms marketplace is markedly different from other types of illegal trade due to the complexity of logistics, secrecy and shipping processes. Send via standard mail is almost impossible because the sellers usually send by separating the pieces of the gun mounting instructions and transmits to the receiver in separate packages. Alternatively, the use of Deceptive documents allows the transportation of weapons by road or sea, and in this process, it is made difficult to track them using intermediate storage points (rental warehouses or garages). Due to the high cost of shipping due to weight and size, sellers often apply discounts on bulk orders, thereby

encouraging buyers to buy in larger quantities. In addition, in some marketplaces, sellers offer not only the gun, but also accessories such as ammunition, silencer, night vision binoculars and laser sight in packages. The average delivery time of these packages varies between 2 and 8 weeks depending on the region where the buyer is located, and during this period, the tracking number and estimated arrival date are regularly sent to the buyer. Dec. The complexity of logistics networks makes monitoring the arms trade much more difficult than other types of illicit trade.

Law enforcement agencies state that tracking logistics networks is the most effective method of combating arms trafficking, and 70% of operations in this area are based on intelligence data obtained from inspections at cargo centers. However, the transport of forged documents is sent by separating the pieces of the gun and the capture rate is far lower than quantities of weapons seized on the marketplace and the global volume of 2-3% is equivalent to. Additionally, gun dealers often implement additional security measures to verify buyers' true identities; For example, people making their first purchase are required to deposit a certain amount of cryptocurrency as a deposit. Pay marketplace 85% of the payment methods used in these markets consist of hard-to-trace cryptocurrencies such as Monero, which makes financial analysis almost impossible with traditional methods. The largest customer group of the arms marketplaces is made up of groups in conflict zones, while the second place is occupied by organized crime organizations and individual buyers in need of protection. The constant restructuring of these markets with new domain names and encrypted communication channels makes it very difficult to create a permanent solution for law enforcement, and this cycle forces the authorities to constantly develop new tracking methods.

4.2.3. Cybercrimes

Cybercrime on the Dark Web is not limited to data theft and ransomware, but has become a dynamic ecosystem that is constantly diversifying with new types. Professional attack packages such as zero-day vulnerabilities, persistent backdoor software and network discovery tools specially developed for infiltrating corporate networks are regularly offered for sale on these platforms. Sellers often share demo videos or sample attack reports to prove the effectiveness of their products, thus ensuring that buyers have preliminary information about the product. In addition, stolen data sets are presented in categories such as username and password combinations, email accounts, and internal documents belonging to corporate networks, and this data is usually obtained as a result of large-scale cyber attacks or internal leaks.

Ransomware forms one of the most profitable and widespread branches of the cybercrime economy on the Dark Web, and the groups that develop these software are constantly updating their encryption algorithms and evasion techniques. After carrying out their attacks, these groups usually demand a ransom in cryptocurrency in exchange for decrypting the encrypted data and threaten to publish or completely delete the data if it is not paid. Some ransomware groups demand millions of dollars in ransoms for attacks on large institutions, while they settle for lower amounts for attacks on individual users, thereby generating income from victims of different income levels. In addition to ransomware, persistent threats that have already infiltrated corporate networks and have been

waiting undetected for a long time are also offered for sale October; these accesses are used by the buyer to prepare the ground for further attacks when requested. The price of such access is determined according to the size of the target institution and the security level of the network, and these Sundays serve as a kind of early warning and opportunity system for cybercriminals.

Fake identity documents and passports, fake diplomas and certificates, medical prescriptions and other official documents are also widely sold on the Dark Web, which are often produced by imitating the designs of real government agencies. As part of identity theft, a complete personal identification package is offered, expanded to include first name, last name, address, date of birth, social security number and, in some cases, biometric data. This data, opening credit cards in the victim's name, a bank account, or the creation of fraudulent use of public assistance, such as are used in a wide variety of fraudulent activity. In addition, stolen bank accounts and cryptocurrency wallets are also offered for sale, and these accounts are traded at different price levels depending on the amount of balance on them. All these activities show that the Dark Web has become a center where not only technological crimes, but also traditional fraud methods have undergone digital transformation.

The cybercrime ecosystem on the Dark Web has developed a hierarchy and division of work within itself; different roles such as code developers, network infrastructure providers, data analysts and customer representatives ensure that this underground economy is professionally organized. Sellers organize advertising campaigns on forums to market their products, create reputation systems with user reviews and ratings, and thus gain the trust of new buyers. In addition, arbitration systems that come into play in dispute situations have been established to Decipher disputes between the parties, and these mechanisms increase the long-term sustainability of the platforms. In these Sunday markets, a large part of the sellers remain active for only a few weeks or months, while larger and professional groups can operate with the same identities for years. Although some Sundays have been closed as a result of the operations of law enforcement agencies, the flexible structure of this ecosystem allows new ones to emerge quickly in place of the lost platforms and the activities to continue without interruption.

4.2.4. Child Abuse

Child exploitation materials on the Dark Web constitute one of the most heinous and subject to the harshest criminal penalties segments of the cybercrime ecosystem. These materials are distributed through closed forums or private file sharing networks, which are usually protected by special encryption methods and accessible only to users who have reached a certain level of trust. Anonymity tools such as Tor and I2P to hide their identities and vendors and peers in addition to the addition of encrypted messaging applications and is working to minimise the risk of detection by using virtual private networks. The sharing of these contents is usually carried out with membership-based systems, and in order for new users to enter the system, existing members must be referenced or monitored for a certain period of time. In addition, the file hosting services used

for storing and distributing these materials are frequently relocated and restructured under different domain names, avoiding tracking by the authorities.

The production of these materials is usually carried out by organized criminal networks, and images of children being abused are delivered to certain customers via live broadcasts or in the form of prerecorded files. Live abuse broadcasts are carried out on Oct. order, and during these broadcasts, viewers can make additional payments for the performance of certain actions. Such activities are supported by financial flows that are extremely difficult to monitor due to payment systems being conducted via cryptocurrencies. In addition, archiving and categorizing abuse materials makes it easier to find these contents, which leads to images of victims being shared repeatedly over the years. The trade of abusive materials is carried out not only by individual criminals, but also by organized groups that produce and distribute these materials.

Law enforcement agencies use advanced digital forensic information techniques, artificial intelligence-supported image recognition systems and international cooperation networks to detect and block these materials. However, the widespread use of anonymity tools, the continuous development of encryption technologies and the increasing level of technical knowledge of criminals keep the capture rates at fairly low levels. In addition, although the platforms hosting these materials are illegal, the methods used by users to hide their identities are becoming increasingly complex, which makes the authorities' job even more difficult. International cooperation is of critical importance in the fight against these crimes, with organizations such as Interpol and Europol coordinating the sharing of information between law enforcement agencies in different countries. Dec. In these operations, the quantity of materials seized and the number of children rescued demonstrate how crucial the struggle is.

The presence of child exploitation materials on the Dark Web also demonstrates how deep and dangerous an underground world these platforms host. Among the users of these materials, there are not only consumers, but also people who produce and distribute these contents, and these networks operate on a global scale. Dec. With the advancement of technology, the methods of production and distribution of abusive materials are also evolving, which constantly poses new challenges for legislators and technology companies. The risk of users encountering such content also shows how dangerous the Dark Web can be for an ordinary internet user. Therefore, public awareness campaigns, parental control software and digital safety trainings in schools have become an important part of the fight against these crimes. Finally, the work of law enforcement agencies in this area is of vital importance in terms of identifying and recovering the identities of victims, preventing these crimes and bringing the perpetrators to justice.

4.2.5. Money Laundering

Money laundering activities on the Dark Web function as a complex and multi-layered financial ecosystem that allows the proceeds of drugs, weapons and cybercrime to be integrated into the legal system. The basis of this process is the use of cryptocurrencies such as Bitcoin, Monero and Zcash;

especially hard-to-trace digital assets such as Monero have become the most preferred tool of money launderers thanks to advanced encryption techniques that hide the transaction history. The whitening process typically consists of three stages: placement, layering, and integration; During the settlement phase, illicit proceeds are introduced into the system through cryptocurrency exchanges or peer-to-peer platforms. At the stratification stage, these funds are quickly transferred between multiple wallets, passed through Decryption services and converted into different types of cryptocurrencies, making tracking efforts greatly difficult. These confusing services collect transactions of hundreds of different users in a pool, hiding the source and destination of funds and thus becoming untraceable.

Money laundering services on the Dark Web are usually offered by professional intermediaries who work in exchange for a certain commission, and these services include cryptocurrency mixers, conversion services, and Decoy trading platforms. These intermediaries charge fees at rates that vary depending on the size of the amount they launder and attract large-scale criminal organizations by applying lower commission rates on high-volume transactions. In addition, transactions made through fake online stores and fictitious service providers are allowed to enter funds into the banking system by pretending to be legitimate business activities, and this method is often used to circumvent the supervisory mechanisms of traditional financial institutions. These fake trading platforms are virtual stores created solely for the purpose of making black money appear as legitimate income, without offering real products or services. In some cases, criminal organizations establish their own cryptocurrency exchanges or pay processor services, conducting the entire laundering process under their own control, thereby eliminating dependence on third parties.

At the integration stage into the traditional banking system, laundered funds are converted into high-value assets such as real estate investments, luxury car purchases or offshore company installations and included in the legal economy, and this stage constitutes the point at which black money is almost completely eliminated from supervisory mechanisms. At this stage, criminal organizations usually distribute funds further and minimize traceability by using tools such as bank accounts in different countries, cryptocurrency-based credit cards or digital asset investment funds. Although law enforcement agencies and financial supervisory authorities have developed blockchain analysis tools, transaction monitoring systems and international information sharing networks to prevent these activities, the increasing rate of use of privacy-oriented cryptocurrencies such as Monero is making this struggle increasingly difficult. In addition, the majority of the money to be laundered moves through decentralized financial platforms that are not controlled by any central authority and are exempt from the regulatory framework; This situation further highlights the gap in traditional regulatory frameworks in this area. International organizations, such as the Financial Action Task Force, are constantly developing new Decrees of recommendation and regulatory frameworks to combat this problem and are trying to increase inter-country cooperation in this area.

4.2.6. Criminal Support Services

Instead of selling illegal products directly, crime support services on the Dark Web offer a wide range of professional services that help criminals make their activities more effective, safe and profitable. These services include decriminalised versions of applications familiar from the legitimate business world, such as digital identity creation, fake document editing, hosting services, legal consulting, and even customer service that deals with user complaints. While sellers and intermediaries develop scoring systems, reference mechanisms and refund policies in order to appear more reliable to their customers, these platforms also establish collaborations among themselves for the development and improvement of decriminalization tools.

Fake identity and document services, one of the most basic pillars of this ecosystem, fully supply customers with the credentials, passports, driver's licenses and invoices they need to open a bank account, become a member of cryptocurrency exchanges or conduct legitimate business activities. These documents are produced with such high quality that they often go unnoticed by automated verification systems and even by untrained human eyes. In addition, within the scope of these services, physical security elements such as holograms, special inks and textured papers imitating the security prints of official institutions are also prepared with great care. In addition to identities, infrastructure services such as company formation, office rental and bank account opening are also offered, and these services allow criminals to establish a presence in the legal world.

Hosting and infrastructure services form the technical infrastructure of criminal activities, and the providers providing these services provide technical solutions such as server, network bandwidth and DDoS protection necessary for the uninterrupted operation of illegal platforms. These providers usually use data centers in countries where legal regulations are looser or law enforcement agencies are inactive, and pay all payments through anonymous cryptocurrencies. In addition, within the scope of these infrastructure services, emergency plans are also provided for the backup of criminal platforms, domain name change and deactivation to enable customers to continue their activities. This highly organized structure makes the Dark Web no longer just a marketplace, but an integrated service center that meets all the needs of criminal activities

4.2.7. Human Trafficking

Human trafficking on the Dark Web stands out as one of the most lucrative areas of operation for organized crime networks, affecting millions of victims worldwide. These platforms offer services in different categories such as human trafficking, forced labor, sexual exploitation and organ trafficking, and these services are usually managed by intermediaries focused on a specific region or country. Victims are often selected from vulnerable individuals who are experiencing economic difficulties or have fled war zones, and Decoyed by false promises of job opportunities, educational opportunities or a better life promised to these people. Sellers use multi-layered logistical solutions such as forged travel documents, bribed customs officials, and organized smuggling networks to transport victims to a specific region.

In the functioning of human trafficking Sundays, victims are classified as commodities and divided into categories according to criteria such as age, gender, physical characteristics, education level. In the trade for the purpose of sexual exploitation, photos and personal information of victims are shown to potential buyers for a certain fee, and these buyers can examine the victim in detail before buying. In cases of forced labor, the victims are employed in a wide range of fields, from agricultural labor to the construction sector, from household services to textile factories, and these people are either not paid at all or are prevented from escaping by borrowing during their work. Organ trafficking is the darkest and least common of these Sundays, but hosts the highest amount of transactions; victims' organs, such as kidneys, liver or cornea, are usually forcibly or tricked into being removed and sold to international buyers.

The logistics network of this trade is supported by methods such as fake travel documents and bribed border officials during the transfer of victims from one country to another, and the movements of victims are carried out by specially rented vehicles, trucks with fake license plates or small watercraft. In order to keep the victims under control and prevent their escape, their passports are confiscated, threats and violent methods are used, and in some cases pressure is applied to their families. In this process, special hosting points are used to hide the identities and locations of victims, and these points are usually selected as places away from supervision, such as rented houses, abandoned warehouses or hotel rooms. In addition, during the sales process of the victims, detailed information such as the victims' medical histories, psychological conditions and previous work experiences are also provided to the buyers and thus it is ensured that the buyers choose the most suitable victim for their needs.

The people who act as intermediaries on these Sundays organize into special teams to ensure that all processes from procurement to transportation of victims, from hosting to selling, run smoothly. Some groups use psychological control methods to prevent victims from rebelling or trying to escape, and these methods include pitting victims against each other, constantly threatening them, or trying to get them to obey with small rewards. Dec. After the sale of the victims is completed, they are usually operated under intensive supervision by the new owners, and this audit process leads to the continuation of long-term victimization of the victims. Since such networks operate on an international scale, tracking down and rescuing these victims through cross-border operations is becoming an extremely complex process.

4.2.8. Terrorism

Terrorist activities carried out via the Dark Web pose a serious threat to security forces around the world, and these platforms offer unique opportunities for providing logistics, communication and financing to terrorist organizations. Terrorist organizations actively use these platforms to recruit members, plan actions, spread propaganda and distribute educational materials, and make maximum use of anonymity tools in this process. These groups create their own private forums and encrypted messaging channels on the Dark Web, developing closed communication networks that make it almost impossible for security forces to intervene.

Through these platforms, a wide range of educational documents and video content is distributed to terrorist organizations, from bomb-making manuals to weapons use trainings, from cyber attack methods to tactical war strategies. These materials are usually encrypted and stored in multiple layers and can only be accessed by users who have reached a certain level of trust. In addition, these materials are adapted to address different languages and different geographical regions, so that they are aimed at reaching a wider audience. In order for new participants to enter the system, existing members must be monitored by reference or for a certain period of time, and thus infiltration attempts by the security forces are largely prevented. These educational materials are diversified to cover not only physical attacks, but also cyber attacks and digital sabotage, allowing terrorist organizations to go beyond traditional methods.

On the financing side, terrorist organizations organize fundraising campaigns on the Dark Web, secretly move their funds through cryptocurrency transfers and use these funds for the purchase of weapons, ammunition and logistical materials. These financial flows are often routed through innocent-looking frontline organizations, such as charities or non-governmental organizations, which can circumvent traditional supervisory mechanisms. In addition, these organizations make their fundraising activities more secure by setting up their own cryptocurrency exchanges or using special pay processor services, and the entire process is protected by technologies that provide anonymity. These sources of financing help organizations not only to maintain their current activities, but also to create the necessary budget for planning new actions and recruiting new members.

The communication and coordination processes of the organizations among themselves are carried out through Decrypted messaging applications, e-mail services and file sharing platforms and these communication channels are regularly changed or taken out of use. This dynamic structure makes it very difficult for security forces to collect intelligence and monitor the activities of organizations, and organizations are constantly developing new platforms and communication methods to turn this situation into an advantage. Although the institutions fighting terrorism on the Dark Web have developed advanced technological solutions, international cooperation networks and intelligence sharing mechanisms to prevent these activities, the organizations' ability to adapt and constantly changing tactics make this struggle even more complicated. This ecosystem not only provides terrorist organizations with the opportunity to continue their current activities, but also provides them with the opportunity to develop new methods of attack and expand their sphere of influence on a global scale.

5. Key Words and Their Definitions

Cyber Crime Prevention: Covers the development of national and international preventive strategies against criminal networks operating over the dark web. These strategies aim to harmonize existing legal regulations, strengthen the cyber security infrastructure and increase the proactive intervention capacity of law enforcement agencies. Additionally, it also includes establishing information sharing mechanisms between public institutions and the private sector.

Cryptocurrency Monitoring: Enables real-time tracking of anonymous cryptocurrency transfers used by criminal organizations through blockchain analytics. This method allows illegal fund flows to be detected, frozen, and seized. It also covers the development of analysis techniques for mixer (tumbler) and privacy-oriented coins (Monero, Zcash).

Financial Intelligence: Includes the collection and analysis of suspicious transaction reports and the mapping of financial networks linked to darknet trading. The intelligence obtained constitutes critical evidence in the fight against money laundering and terrorist financing. International data sharing between financial intelligence units plays a decisive role in uncovering transnational criminal networks.

Marketplace Paid Digital Traces of Drug Trafficking: Refers to the systematic monitoring of all digital footprints, such as logistics, payments, communications and user comments on drug sales made on Darknet marketplaces. These traces are used for mapping the supply chain, identifying producing countries, and planning international joint operations. Additionally, it enables the detection of the market entry of new synthetic drug types through early warning systems.

Arms Trade Links: Aims to decipher illegal arms sales conducted on the dark web through buyerseller networks, pay channels and shipping routes. Uncovering these connections directly contributes to the prevention of regional conflicts and organized acts of violence. Additionally, it helps close loopholes in legal supply chains by ensuring that weapons reach their countries of origin.

Human Trafficking Digital Marketing: Aims to detect the marketing of victims on the dark web through advertising, ads or hidden forums and to quickly remove these contents. Digital marketing traces are the main evidence for the identities of perpetrators, the hierarchy of trafficking networks and operations aimed at rescuing victims. The struggle in this field also requires cooperation with civil society organizations.

Encryption and Private Key: Includes end-to-end encryption used by criminal networks in their communications and transactions, as well as the analysis of private key systems by forensic methods. This technique makes it necessary to observe a delicate balance with the protection of individual privacy rights and freedom of communication while providing access to encrypted data.

The technical capacity of judicial authorities in this field is a prerequisite for successful investigations.

Marketplace on the Darknet: The closure of these platforms where illegal goods and services are traded aims to bring the management staff to justice with international cooperation and to prevent the emergence of alternative marketplaces. Operations targeting marketplaces directly weaken the economic infrastructure of organized crime and provide deterrence. These operations also involve infiltration activities and digital evidence collection processes.

Cyber Patrol: Refers to the intelligence gathering of law enforcement agencies by conducting active virtual patrol activities on the dark web with secret identities and special access methods. This activity enables the detection of criminal organizations' plans at an early stage, the protection of potential victims and the acceleration of operational response processes. Cyber patrol goes beyond passive monitoring and offers a preventive approach.

Digital Evidence Management: Covers the collection, preservation, analysis and presentation of electronic evidence obtained from the dark web in accordance with the rules of forensic computing. Maintaining the integrity of the chain of evidence and preserving data integrity is of vital importance for the international validity and admissibility of cases. This process requires the development of standardized protocols.

Ransomware: Ransomware attacks coordinated by criminal networks over the dark web and includes tracking of cryptocurrency payouts requested in these attacks. Blocking or interrupting these payments eliminates the economic motivation of cyber attacks and contributes to deterring future attacks. Additionally, it also encompasses the establishment of support mechanisms for victimized institutions.

International Legal Assistance: Refers to the legal framework governing the sharing of evidence between countries, the establishment of joint investigation teams, the extradition of suspects and the confiscation of assets in transboundary darknet investigations. Dec. Effective and rapid judicial cooperation enables the dismantling of global criminal networks that no single country can combat alone. This process includes bilateral and multilateral agreements, as well as the use of international platforms such as Interpol and Europol.

Capacity Building: Aims to train law enforcement, judicial and prosecutor's office members in developing countries on darknet investigation techniques, digital forensic informatics and cyber security and strengthen their technical equipment. In this way, it is aimed to bridge the capability gap between countries in the global struggle and enable all countries to acquire effective response capabilities. Capacity building also includes technical assistance programs and joint exercises.

6. Background of the Issue

The rapid development of the internet has created new opportunities for communication, commerce, and information sharing, but it has also provided organized criminal groups with new tools to conduct illegal activities. Among these developments, the emergence of the Dark Web has become a significant concern for international law enforcement agencies. The Dark Web refers to a part of the internet that is intentionally hidden from conventional search engines and generally requires specialized software or configurations to access. While anonymity can serve legitimate purposes, including protecting journalists, activists, and individuals living under censorship, the same characteristics can also be exploited by criminal organizations.

The relationship between the Dark Web and organized crime has developed significantly over the past decade. Criminal networks have used anonymous online platforms and marketplaces to facilitate activities such as drug trafficking, the illegal trade of weapons, stolen personal information, counterfeit documents, and various forms of cybercrime. These platforms can connect buyers and sellers from different countries while making it more difficult for traditional law enforcement methods to identify the individuals involved. Cryptocurrency and other digital payment systems may further complicate investigations by allowing criminal transactions to take place across borders without relying on conventional financial institutions.

One of the most significant concerns for the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) is the ability of criminal networks to operate internationally. A single criminal organization may have members, infrastructure, financial resources, and victims located in several different jurisdictions. Consequently, investigating and prosecuting these networks often requires cooperation between multiple national authorities. Differences in national legislation, investigative powers, evidence requirements, and definitions of cybercrime can create additional obstacles to effective international action.

Law enforcement agencies have taken various measures to combat criminal activity on the Dark Web. International investigations have resulted in the identification and dismantling of several major illicit marketplaces and criminal networks. However, the closure of one platform does not necessarily eliminate the underlying criminal ecosystem. New platforms can emerge, criminal actors can migrate to alternative services, and increasingly sophisticated technologies can make investigations more complex. This creates a continuing challenge for authorities attempting to balance effective law enforcement with privacy, cybersecurity, and fundamental rights.

Another major challenge is the rapidly changing nature of digital technology. Criminal networks can adapt their methods as governments develop new investigative techniques and regulations. This technological evolution requires law enforcement agencies to continuously improve their technical expertise, investigative capabilities, and international cooperation mechanisms.

Therefore, combating criminal networks operating on the Dark Web requires more than simply targeting individual websites or marketplaces. It requires a comprehensive international approach involving information sharing, coordinated investigations, capacity building, appropriate legal frameworks, financial crime prevention, and cooperation between governments, international organizations, law enforcement agencies, and relevant private-sector actors. Addressing these challenges while respecting human rights and legitimate uses of anonymity remains a central issue for the international community.

7.Previous and Ongoing Efforts

7.1. Biggest and International Operations

7.1.1. Operation Alice (March 2026) – The Largest Dark Web Operation In History

Operation Alice represents one of the most significant law enforcement operations ever conducted against criminal networks on the dark web. The global operation, which was launched on March 9, 2026 and will continue until March 19, 2026, was led by the German authorities; it was carried out with the significant support of Europol and involved the participation of law enforcement agencies from 23 countries. The investigation began in mid-2021, initially focusing on a platform called “Alice with Violence CP”, but later a much more extensive network was uncovered.

The operation targeted a single operator, identified as a 35-year-old Chinese citizen, who created and managed a vast infrastructure of more than 373,000 fake onion domain names. These websites are designed to advertise illegal content and services, including child sexual abuse materials (CSAM), stolen credit card information, and various cybercrime services. However, the platform essentially operated as an advanced fraud system; They convinced users to make Bitcoin payments, but did not provide any illegal content or services in return.

Authorities have determined that the operator manages up to 287 servers during its busiest period, and 105 of these are located in Germany. As a result, an international arrest warrant was issued. The Deceptive CSAM "packages" were priced between 17 and 215 euros and promised data ranging from a few gigabytes to terabytes; however, in reality, no content was delivered. In addition to CSAM, cybercrime services such as stolen credit card information and system access have also been introduced on the platform, and paying users have been defrauded.

The results of the operation have been quite extensive: more than 373,000 dark websites have been shut down, 105 servers have been confiscated, and computers, mobile phones and other electronic devices have been seized. 440 customers have been identified worldwide, and investigations are ongoing regarding more than 100 individuals. Europol has emphasized that the fact that customers pay to purchase such materials, even if they have never received CSAM, makes them suspicious, and investigators consider these people to be high-value targets in terms of obtaining intelligence.

In a particularly noteworthy case, a 31-year-old father was convicted in 2023 for attempting to purchase 70 GB of CSAM. This situation demonstrates how quickly authorities take action to protect children. Europol coordinated international information sharing, assisted in monitoring cryptocurrency payments, and supported the identification of perpetrators. The institution also carries out activities such as the “Stop Child Abuse – Trace an Object” initiative aimed at preventing child sexual abuse and the Help4U platform, which offers safe advice and support to children.

7.1.2. Operation Cronos (February 2024) - Deactivation of the Lockbit Ransomware

On February 19, 2024, the UK National Crime Agency (NCA), the FBI, Europol, and partner agencies from 11 countries announced Operation Cronos. The operation was a coordinated effort against LockBit, the most effective ransomware group of the previous three years. NCA exploited a vulnerability called CVE-2023-3824 in a PHP-based component of the LockBit infrastructure to provide administrator access to LOCKBIT's affiliate panel. This technical access provided a rare insight into the list of criminals affiliated with law enforcement agencies, payment flows, and victim communications.

A total of 34 servers were confiscated in the Netherlands, Germany, Finland, France, Switzerland, Australia, the USA and the United Kingdom as part of the operation; in addition, more than 200 cryptocurrency wallets and domain names used on LOCKBIT's leak site and affiliate panel were seized. Two people connected with LockBit have been arrested in Poland and Ukraine, and the US Department of Justice has publicly announced indictments against two Russian citizens connected with LockBit activities, Artur Sungatov and Ivan Kondratyev (Bassterlord).

The NCA has replaced LOCKBIT's leak site on the dark web with an interception message, released a free decryption tool for victims affected by certain versions of LockBit 3.0, and increased pressure on the group's members by gradually sharing operational details. NCA and FBI have released the decryption tool through the No More Ransom platform. However, the tool only works on files encrypted with certain versions of LockBit, from which the NCA obtained the decryption keys from the compromised infrastructure. The Japan National Police Agency also conducted significant forensic informatics studies and contributed to the development of the decryption tool.

It is estimated that the operation resulted in approximately an 80% reduction in LockBit-related attacks within two months. Europol coordinated the cross-border aspect of the operation and documented that there were at least 14,000 fake accounts on the linked services. However, the LockBit administrator established a new leak site on February 24, 2024, just five days after the operation began. This situation demonstrated how quickly the group was able to restructure. In spite of this, results revealed three permanent operations: connected weakened trust between the criminals, crime, provided intelligence and coordinated combat operations continues to be used in the new indictment has revealed tangible results.

7.1.3. Operation First Light (2024) – Dismantling Global Fraud Networks

Operation First Light 2024 is a global police operation spanning 61 countries. The operation targeted online criminal networks such as phishing, investment fraud, fake online shopping sites, romance fraud and impersonation scams. As a result of the operation, 3,950 suspects were arrested and 14,643 more individuals were identified as potential suspects. The police seized approximately $135 million worth of fiat currency and $2 million worth of cryptocurrency; in addition, over $120 million in assets were seized, including real estate, luxury vehicles, expensive jewelry and other valuable assets.

Authorities used INTERPOL's Global Rapid Intervention of Payments (I-GRIP) mechanism to track and stop illicit proceeds. For example, in a business email fraud case where a Spanish victim transferred money to Hong Kong, the funds were tracked and stopped. In another case, Australian authorities successfully recovered 5.5 million Australian dollars (US$3.7 million) transferred to the bank accounts of a victim of impersonation fraud in Malaysia and Hong Kong.

Among the notable results of the operation is the Deconstruction of a sophisticated international fraud network operating in the Namibian capital. In this operation, 88 young people who were forced to carry out fraudulent activities were rescued; 163 computers and 350 mobile phones were seized. Thanks to the coordination between the Singapore Police Force's Anti-Scam Center and the Hong Kong Police Force's Anti-Deception Coordination Center, an attempted technology support scam was thwarted and a 70-year-old victim was prevented from losing his savings worth 380,000 Singapore dollars (US$281,200). Joint investigations by Brazilian and Portuguese authorities have also neutralized various fraud networks operating on a global scale.

Director of the INTERPOL Financial Crimes and Corruption Combating Centre (IFCACC), Dr. Regarding the results of the operation, Isaac Kehinde Oginni stated that these results are not just numbers; they represent protected lives, prevented crimes and a healthier global economy. He also stated that the seizure of large amounts of money and the blocking of the activities of the criminal organizations behind these networks have dealt a significant blow to organized crime groups.

7.1.4. Archetyp Market Operation (June 2025) – Europe's Longest-Running Drug Market

Law enforcement agencies across Europe, one of Europe's longest operating businesses, successfully undermines the dark web drug market archetyp. Eurojust and Europol supported by six countries participated in the large-scale operation in the course of between 11-13 June 2025 Germany, the Netherlands, Romania, Spain and Sweden, he participated in approximately 300 operations and coordinated the operations tasked.

Archetyp Sunday has been operating as a drug market for more than five years, has reached more than 600,000 users worldwide and has a transaction volume of at least 250 million euros. There have been more than 17,000 ads on the platform and it has become one of the few dark web Sundays that allows the sale of fentanyl and other highly potent synthetic opioids, which pose a growing threat in Europe and around the world.

The platform infrastructure in the Netherlands has been disabled and a 31-year-old German citizen identified as its manager has been arrested in Barcelona, Spain. At the same time, transactions were carried out in Germany and Sweden against a moderator and some of the six largest sellers of the Sunday, and assets worth 7.8 million euros were confiscated. German prosecutors later charged the operator in question with managing the platform since July 2020 and obtaining about 20 million euros in income as part of an organized crime syndicate.

June November 2022 to June 2025 alone, about 2.3 million orders were processed through the platform, and the estimated transaction volume reached about 330 million euros. Dec. More than 600,000 customer accounts have been registered, and the cryptocurrency called Monero has been used as the primary payment method. It has been claimed that the operator receives a 5% commission from each sale. If found guilty, the suspect could face up to 15 years in prison, as well as confiscation of assets with a total value of about 10 million euros, including cryptocurrency, cash and luxury vehicles.

Jean-Philippe Lecouffe, Europol Deputy Director General for Operations, assessed the importance of the operation as follows: "With this operation, law enforcement agencies have eliminated one of the longest-operating drug Sundays on the dark web, cutting off an important supply line for some of the world's most dangerous substances. By dismantling its infrastructure and arresting key figures, we make it clear that there is no safe haven for those who profit from harm."

7.2. Education Programs and Development Movements

7.2.1. Jamaica UNODC Training – Project SALIENT (17-21 March 2025)

The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) organized a special training on the investigation of firearms trafficking carried out on the dark web in Jamaica between March 17 Dec-21st, 2025 as part of Project SALIENT. A total of 22 officers, including 7 women, from important national institutions such as the Jamaica Police Force, the Jamaica Customs Agency, the Major Organized Crime and Anti-Corruption Agency and the Financial Investigations Unit, participated in the training.

The training covered the differences between the surface web, deep web, and dark web, and how criminals use these platforms for illegal activities. Participants were provided with practical information on using tools such as Tor and VPN to protect operational security (OpSec) and reduce the risk of leaving digital traces. Practical training was carried out on special software used for tracking and monitoring illegal activities related to firearms trafficking.

Sunday Sunday, participants learned how to safely navigate the dark web, identify illegal markets and analyze the structures of these markets in order to understand how illegal firearms transactions occur. Cryptocurrencies such as Bitcoin and Monero, blockchain analysis techniques, tracking illegal transactions, decryption of wallet addresses, legal issues related to the seizure of cryptocurrencies and cooperation between financial institutions and cryptocurrency exchanges were also discussed.

In the hands-on study called “Hands-On Bitcoin” within the scope of the training, participants created wallets on the test network and made transactions, gaining direct experience in cryptocurrency investigations.

In addition, the role of encryption in criminal activities and methods for law enforcement agencies to analyze encryption systems such as PGP in investigations were discussed in the training. The successful completion of the training has been an important step in strengthening Jamaica's capacity to combat firearms trafficking carried out through the dark web.

7.2.2. Qatar UNODC Regional Centre - Ongoing Training Program (2024-2026)

The UNODC Regional Centre for Combating Cybercrime in Doha was established under an agreement signed in 2023 between UNODC and the State of Qatar. The center has become an important center where structured training is carried out on the prevention of cybercrimes and the fight against them.

The ongoing training program covers topics such as cryptocurrency investigations, dark web and OSINT investigations, electronic evidence and drug-related money laundering.

The center's training programs are designed for participants with different levels of experience and include applied studies, case analyses and scenario-based learning methods. The center operates

within the UNODC Global Cybercrime Program, which operates in 105 countries. The program supports member states in six main areas: cyber investigations, digital forensics, digital evidence, virtual assets, child sexual abuse materials and prevention.

This training shows that Qatar is taking on an increasingly important role as a regional capacitybuilding center for combating cybercrime through the UNODC center. The Center provides support to member states in protecting their institutions and societies against emerging digital threats.

7.2.3. Ukraine UNODC Project (2025-2028)

UNODC has expanded its work in Ukraine as part of a three-year project funded by Canada. The project aims to strengthen Ukraine's capacity to combat cybercrime and organized crime, including crimes linked to the dark web.

Within the scope of the project, it is planned to establish educational facilities and mobile forensic IT laboratories, to cooperate with the Prosecutor's Office, the National Police and the Ministry of Education.

Within the scope of the studies, support was given to the implementation of initial training programs nationwide on international standards, assessments were carried out to determine the risks of crime and corruption, and reports were published on organized crime trends during the war and the risks faced by Ukrainian refugees in terms of human trafficking.

8. UNODC's Approach to Combating Dark Web Criminal Networks

UNODC fights dark web criminal networks by helping countries build their technical skills in digital forensics, tracking cryptocurrency, and sharing information across borders. Instead of just stopping single crimes, it uses a smart system-analysis method to break down the main money, supply, and communication networks of organized crime groups.

The UNODC combats criminal networks on the dark web under the framework of two distinct programs: Global Programme on Cybercrime (GPC) and Global Programme on Criminal Network Disruption (GPCD). These programs are used to tackle cybercrime and organized crime networks on a global scale.

GPC (Global Programme on Cybercrime), focuses on strengthening member state's technical capabilities to investigate cybercrime, monitor the dark web, trace cryptocurrencies, and manage digital evidence, while enhancing international legal cooperation.

GPCD (Global Programme on Criminal Network Disruption), utilizes intelligence and a systems analysis approach to identify vulnerabilities in transnational organized crime groups, systematically targeting and dismantling their financial, logistical, and communication structures.

8.1. Education Expertise and Capacity Development

To sustainably combat cybercrime networks that evolve daily due to the anonymity and complex technological infrastructures of the dark web, UNODC focuses on enhancing the professional expertise, modernizing the technical infrastructure, and building international-standard investigative capacity among member state's law enforcement officers, digital forensics experts, prosecutors and judges:

Specialized Technical Training: Equipping investigators with the skills to monitor dark web marketplaces, trace illicit cryptocurrency transfers, and collect digital evidence securely.

Digital Forensics Capabilities: Providing practical training and technical equipment to police units and forensic lab technicians to analyze computers, servers, and mobile devices seized during operations.

Legal and Judicial Workshops: Training prosecutors and judges on how to properly handle electronic evidence, navigate cybercrime legislation, and assess the legal validity of digital proof in court.

Cross-Border Mentorship and Knowledge Sharing: Connecting local law enforcement agencies with international experts to exchange best practices, modern investigation tools, and up-to-date countermeasure strategies.

8.2. International Operation Coordination

Since Dark Web criminal networks operate across borders without geographical limits, UNODC acts as a global facilitator to streamline joint operations, standardize cross-border legal procedures, and build trust among international law enforcement entities. This strategic coordination ensures that national borders do not become barriers when investigating complex cybercrimes and disrupting illicit digital infrastructures.

8.3. Public-Private Sector Collaboration

The UNODC does not work alone in combating criminal networks on the dark web, it engages in certain public-private sector collaborations.

UNODC gains global operational reach through INTERPOL. While UNODC establishes the legal framework, INTERPOL plays an active role in the field. Illegal trade conducted via the Dark Web is targeted on a global scale through joint operations, such as internationally coordinated raids.

The technical field successes of the FBI and national law enforcement agencies play a significant role in the fight against cybercrime. The technical field experiences of national giants in this arena, such as the FBI (which dismantled massive dark web marketplaces like AlphaBay) or the UK's NCA, are compiled by the UNODC as "best practices" to serve as a guide for countries around the world.

UNODC engages in cross-border judicial cooperation with Eurojust. Cybercrimes do not respect borders; therefore, collaborating with judicial authorities like Eurojust facilitates the lawful sharing of digital evidence across jurisdictions and ensures the proper organization of prosecution cases.

UNODC maintains a strategic and institutional partnership with EUROPOL to enhance operational capacity while developing global policies and legal frameworks. The two organizations collaborate particularly on data sharing, threat analysis, and the monitoring of crime trends.

The Private Sector and Cybersecurity Giants: A broad network of private entities—from tech giants like Microsoft (for threat intelligence) to blockchain analytics firms like Chainalysis—shares data to unmask the anonymous cryptocurrency flows and cyber vulnerabilities hiding behind the Dark Web.

8.4. Research and Threat Analysis

UNODC continuously monitors the evolution of dark web marketplaces to identify emerging illicit products, cryptocurrencies, and anonymization technologies utilized by criminal organizations.

The Office publishes comprehensive analytical reports and policy briefs that synthesize global data on cybercrime and dark web activities, helping Member States understand evolving operational tactics.

By transforming complex threat data into actionable intelligence, UNODC equips governments and law enforcement agencies with the strategic insights needed to develop targeted, evidence-based countermeasures.

Selected reports include:

UNODC Darknet Threat Assessment (Darknet Threat Assessment Reports): A series of foundational global studies examining illicit trade on the Dark Web, synthetic opioid stockpiles, cryptocurrency usage rates, and marketplace dynamics.
Darknet Cybercrime Threats to Southeast Asia (Darknet Cybercrime Threats in Southeast Asia Report): A comprehensive UNODC case study providing a regional analysis of Dark Web market

distribution, languages used, local cybercrime networks, data gaps faced by law enforcement, and tactical trends.

Global Synthetic Drug Assessment / Cybercrime Research Briefs: Regularly updated analytical bulletins mapping the market for synthetic substances and chemical precursors across online platforms and the Dark Web.

8.5. Awareness and Prevention Campaigns

UNODC recognizes that enforcement alone cannot dismantle cyber-dependent criminal ecosystems, making proactive public awareness and community prevention vital pillars of its strategy.
UNODC designs targeted educational initiatives and global campaigns to alert young people, parents, and educators to the hidden dangers of the digital underground, including how criminal networks use anonymized networks for recruitment, exploitation, and illicit trade.

By equipping civil society and local institutions with digital literacy toolkits, these preventive programs build community resilience and disrupt the pipeline that draws vulnerable individuals into cybercrime before illicit activities even begin.

UNODC Global Youth Crime Prevention Initiatives: Programs implemented globally to steer at-risk youth away from cybercrime, teaching them about the long-term legal consequences of digital offenses and preventing online recruitment by dark web syndicates.

Cybersecurity and Digital Literacy Toolkits for Schools: Educational campaigns and resource guides rolled out in collaboration with local stakeholders to help students, parents, and teachers identify early warning signs of online exploitation and malicious digital grooming.

"Listen First" and Community Resilience Campaigns: While initially focused on health and drug prevention, UNODC's evidence-based family and community skill-building frameworks are frequently adapted to foster digital resilience, empowering communities to recognize the psychological tactics used by bad actors online.

8.6. Legal and Regulatory Framework Development

UNODC assists member states in modernizing their national legislation to effectively address cybercrime and dark web criminality, ensuring that domestic laws align with international conventions like the UN Convention against Transnational Organized Crime.

The office provides specialized technical assistance for drafting legal frameworks that govern electronic evidence collection, cross-border data sharing, and the seizure or confiscation of virtual assets and cryptocurrencies used in illicit dark web transactions.

By bridging gaps between differing national legal systems, UNODC helps eliminate safe havens for cybercriminals and fosters seamless international cooperation required for complex transnational prosecutions.

UNODC provides concrete legal and regulatory support through significant global milestones and targeted legislative assistance, exemplified by initiatives such as:

UN Convention on Countering Cybercrime: Serving as the secretariat for this landmark agreement, UNODC helped create the first global, legally binding instrument to combat cyber-dependent crimes. This framework assists Member States in harmonizing their domestic laws, closing legal loopholes, and facilitating the cross-border sharing of electronic evidence.

Model Laws and Specialized Legislative Assistance: UNODC develops practical legal guides and model laws (such as templates for mutual legal assistance and electronic evidence management) to help developing countries update their legal codes. These tools enable local courts to legally process digital evidence and authorize the seizure or confiscation of virtual assets and cryptocurrencies linked to dark web operations.

9. Resolution Should Address

1. What can be done to prevent people from accessing dark web technologies through everyday devices that can be considered normal, such as computers?

2. How can an awareness campaign be conducted to ensure that the difference between the Deep Web and the Dark Web, which are often confused in public discourse, is properly understood?

3. How can international oversight be established to disrupt the crypto-based drug trade and logistics/cargo supply chain on the Dark Web?

4. What kind of AI-supported measures can be taken to detect arms sales made via the Dark Web at the customs and shipping stages?

5. What global steps can be taken to prevent the trade of cyber attack software (Ransomware) and system vulnerabilities sold as a service on the Dark Web?

6. What authority and infrastructure should be provided to law enforcement agencies to block child exploitation content on the Dark Web and identify anonymous perpetrators?

7. How should cryptocurrency mixers handling dark web criminal proceeds be configured to comply with international financial monitoring controls?

8. What operational strategies should be implemented to dismantle the infrastructure of actors providing "support services" such as fake IDs, passports, or contract killers?

9. How can data sharing be established between cyber intelligence and border units to uncover human trafficking networks operating on the Dark Web?

10. How can international intelligence cooperation be strengthened to prevent terrorist organizations from using the Dark Web for financing, propaganda, and recruitment?

10. Bibliography

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/United_Nations_Office_on_Drugs_and_Crime
www.bbc.com/turkce/haberler-dunya-59952344

https://newsinteractives.cbc.ca/longform/the-new-frontier-of-the-drug-trade
https://www.fbi.gov/news/stories/global-operation-targets-darknet-drug-trafficking
https://www.europol.europa.eu/media-press/newsroom/news/europe-wide-takedown-hits-longeststanding-dark-web-drug-market

https://www.europol.europa.eu/media-press/newsroom/news/europe-wide-takedown-hits-longeststanding-dark-web-drug-market

https://www.justice.gov/usao-ma/pr/leader-dark-web-drug-trafficking-operation-sentenced-eightyears-prison-and-59-bitcoin

https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/firearms-protocol/news/2024/Mar/unodc-leads-hands-on-trainingon-dark-web-firearms-trafficking-investigations.html

https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/3929854

https://www.rand.org/randeurope/research/projects/2017/international-arms-trade-on-the-hiddenweb.html

https://syntheticdrugs.unodc.org/syntheticdrugs/en/cybercrime/detectandrespond/investigation/darknet.html

https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/organized-crime/index.html

https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/cybercrime/home.html

https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/gpcd/gpcd-approach.html

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Europol